

Good morning,

I just spoke with the principal at the Lyseth School in North Deering. The principal was concerned about sending us the requested information on people with cancer and violating their privacy. For this reason, a letter was sent out to the parents of all the children at the Lyseth School to request permission to share the 9 pieces of information we requested. I'm not sure why they didn't just send the letter to the 29 individuals they were concerned about, but as a result there will be more than 29 cases reported to us. One of the parents released the letter to the news.

The principal will send us all the information she receives, including additional cases beyond the 29, since the concern is about the North Deering neighborhood rather than the Lyseth School. We will then evaluate the information according to our routine procedure. We will look at the overall number of cases in North Deering to see if it is higher than expected. We are working with the the City of Portland to get accurate population counts for the neighborhood.

Thank you,
Castine

-----Original Message-----

From: Mills, Dora A.

Sent: Monday, February 12, 2007 6:02 PM

To: Poirier, Barbara

Cc: Schwenn, Molly; Verrill, Castine; Martins, John A; Zukas-Lessard, Chris

Subject: RE: North Deering Cancer Concern

Importance: High

Thank you for the information. I suspect that they interpreted the letter, then, as meaning that they should be recruiting their own reporting system for cancer cases, as apparently that's the tone of the letter - "let us know if you know of anyone with cancer, we'll report it to the Me CDC". I think we thought they knew of 29 cases and we just needed to know whom they are. However, I thought our overall approach is to look at the prevalence/incidence for the geographical area concerned, and then compare that to an expected rate. Is there someone who can call the school principal, now that this is out in the news, and work with them on this? I'm concerned that the process described by the tv stations (asking for cancer cases to be reported to them) will result in a lot of unnecessary fear.

Dora

From: Poirier, Barbara

Sent: Mon 2/12/2007 5:53 PM

To: Mills, Dora A.

Cc: Schwenn, Molly; Verrill, Castine

Subject: FW: North Deering Cancer Concern

Hi Dora, Castine and Molly told me about Kim's call. Said she was asking about Maine cancer prevalence. Castine, at my request, referred Kim to Kip DeSerre who gave Castine an estimated figure of 40-50,000 based on national data. Below is email request Castine sent to the school back in December and has not heard anything since. Sounds like the school may have initiated the letter. B

I'm in DC and out and about, but got a cell phone call from Channel 13/WGME at ~ noon, asking about a letter that went home to parents of the elementary school that wrote us a few weeks ago expressing concerns about high rates of cancer. They quoted the letter, saying it requests parents to call the school nurse to report any cancer cases, and that they

would then report that information to us! I told them to call Dr. Schwenn, that she would know if we had requested the letter, but to my knowledge we had not. I told them that because cancer is a reportable disease, we normally do not ask the public to report to us cases of cancer. I just returned to the hotel and received another call - this one from Channel 8, saying they had heard a report on WGME (must have been the 5:00 news) and heard about this letter and also wondered what our role is in it. With both, I also emphasized that we get a half dozen to a dozen such inquiries every year and that over the past 25-30 years we've been doing this, we've encountered one possible cluster. However, we take all such inquiries seriously, and it takes usually several months to complete our work in answering people's questions (I purposely did not use the word "investigation").

Can you pls give us an update on this situation? Thank you!! Dora

-----Original Message-----

From: Mills, Dora A.

Sent: Tuesday, December 26, 2006 12:40 PM

To: Verrill, Castine

Cc: Schwenn, Molly; Poirier, Barbara; Zukas-Lessard, Chris

Subject: RE: North Deering Cancer Concern

Thank you very much, Castine, for your quick and thorough reply. Please keep me in the loop. Dora

From: Verrill, Castine

Sent: Tue 12/26/2006 10:00 AM

To: 'porte@portlandschools.org'; 'russep@portlandschools.org';
'mcleo@portlandschools.org'

Cc: Schwenn, Molly; Mills, Dora A.

Subject: North Deering Cancer Concern

Dear All Concerned Parties,

I am writing from the Maine Cancer Registry, a program within the Maine Center for Disease Control and Prevention (formerly the Bureau of Health). Dr. Dora Mills forwarded your letter of concern about cancer in the neighborhood of North Deering. The Maine Cancer Registry takes such concerns seriously and has an established protocol for evaluating these concerns. The first step is to gather information on the 29 cancer cases that have been identified. For each case, we will need to know the following:

1. Name
2. Gender
3. Type of cancer (breast, lung, leukemia, etc.)
4. Year the cancer was diagnosed
5. The person's age when the cancer was diagnosed
6. Where the person was living at the time of diagnosis
7. How long the person had lived at this residence
8. Whether the person is still alive
9. Hospital where the person was diagnosed or treated (if known)

Once this information is received, we will attempt to verify the cases in our database. We will also search for additional cases diagnosed in residents of North Deering. If there are specific environmental concerns, please notify us of these as well. This information will then be reviewed by our Cancer Inquiry Team to determine the appropriate next steps.

The case information above can be shared with me over the phone, fax, or via mail. Please